The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Polls for **Russia's presidential election** closed after three days of voting across the country. Long queues reportedly formed at some polling stations at noon. Supporters of Alexei Navalny—Russia's most prominent opposition leader, who died in prison last month—had called on people to turn at that hour to vote against Mr Putin by way of protest against the sham vote. Yulia Navalnaya, Navalny's widow, attended a noon protest in Berlin. Regardless, the result is certain to be a landslide victory and another six-year term for Vladimir Putin.

Meanwhile Mr Putin accused **Ukraine** of trying to disrupt voting with increased air attacks which targeted critical infrastructure. On Sunday Ukraine said its drones had hit an oil refinery in Krasnodar, in southern Russia, overnight; Russia said it had shot down 35 Ukrainian drones in eight regions.

Binyamin Netanyahu, **Israel's** prime minister, said that he still plans to invade **Rafah**, Gaza's southernmost city, despite international pressure not to. But during a press conference with Olaf Scholz, Germany's chancellor, Mr Netanyahu said that Israel would not keep the as many as 1.5m Palestinians sheltering there "locked in place". A number of Israel's allies have warned Mr Netanyahu against proceeding with the offensive.

Mr Netanyahu also railed against calls by **Chuck Schumer**, the majority leader of America's Senate, for elections in Israel. In an interview he called the comments, which Mr Schumer made on Thursday, "totally inappropriate". Separately, American officials said that the country carried out another airdrop of humanitarian aid into Gaza.

The **European Union** announced a €7.4bn ($8.1bn) aid package for Egypt, which will be delivered within three years. The package is meant to bolster Egypt's ailing economy and limit the number of migrants leaving the country for Europe. The two sides upgraded their relationship to a "strategic partnership", and plan to collaborate in various areas of the economy, including energy and trade.

The ruling military junta in **Niger** revoked a deal that allows **American** soldiers on the country's soil. It accused a visiting American delegation of not following diplomatic protocol. America has two army bases in Niger. Since seizing power in July, the junta —like the military leaders in neighbouring Mali and Burkina Faso —has forced out European forces and aligned itself more closely with Russia.

Iceland declared a state of emergency for the area surrounding a volcano that erupted for the fourth time since December. The eruption, which took place just south of Reykjavik, the capital, was expected by meteorologists. Grindavik, a nearby fishing town home to 4,000 people, was once again evacuated. An earlier eruption had burned some of its homes to the ground.

Word of the week: *Agunot*, the Hebrew term describing Jewish women who are trapped in unwanted marriages. Read the full story.

In the run-up to America's presidential election, we've launched The US in brief—a daily update to help you keep on top of the political stories that matter. Sign up here to receive it as a newsletter, each weekday, in your inbox

Photo: Getty Images

Lib Dems court Conservatives

With a British general election expected this year, the Liberal Democrats are meeting for their spring conference in York this weekend. The junior partners in the coalition government of 2010-15 have been badly reduced in recent years: they are the fourth-largest party by seats in the Westminster Parliament, behind the Scottish National Party. According to *The Economist*'s poll tracker, they have slipped to fourth place in vote share behind Reform, a right-wing insurgent party. On Tuesday Reform staged a coup by recruiting Lee Anderson, an ex-Conservative MP who recently claimed that Islamists controlled London's Muslim mayor.

Sir Ed Davey, the Lib Dems' leader, hopes to end his party's poor run by focusing on disaffected Conservative voters with liberal, pro-EU tendencies in seats in the London commuter belt. The party argues that Tory politicians' conduct has become fetid. It seems to be trying to keep that theme in voters' minds by making sewage dumping a focus of its campaigns.

Photo: Alamy

India’s campaign kicks off

On Saturday India’s election commission announced that it will hold a seven-phase general election, beginning on April 19th. Results will be announced on June 4th. With 945m people eligible to vote, many of them in remote places, the largest democratic exercise in history will be an enormous logistical challenge.

Narendra Modi is widely expected to win a third term—but the past week was an awkward one for the prime minister and his Bharatiya Janata Party. On Thursday the election commission published details about companies and people who had bought electoral bonds. Last month the Supreme Court deemed these controversial campaign-finance instruments unconstitutional. They were introduced by Mr Modi’s government in 2018 and had mainly benefited the BJP. Then, on Friday, the government rushed to appoint two new election commissioners seen as loyal to Mr Modi before the court could hear a challenge to the appointment process. Expect a tumultuous campaign.

Photo: Carlos Jared

Mother’s milk from an unlikely source

Slimy, venomous and alien-looking, the ringed caecilian could have slithered out of a child’s nightmare. This creature is neither worm nor snake, but rather an egg-laying amphibian, native to South America’s marshy forests. Look beyond its chthonic appearance, however, and you will find something more tender: the mammalian ability to feed “milk” to its young. According to a new paper in *Science*, a journal, caecilians have joined a small list of non-mammalian animals that can do so.

Experts observing caecilians noticed the hatchlings nuzzling at their mother’s vent, an opening at her tail end. Apparently in response to the touches and sounds of her babies, the mother secretes a thick clear fluid from glands inside her reproductive tract. Chemical analysis revealed the fluid is rich in fats and carbohydrates, similar to mammalian milk. The discovery makes caecilians’ parenting style unique among amphibians—no others communicate with their offspring in this way. It might make them seem a little more friendly, too.

Photo: Getty Images

A competitive Six Nations

In the Six Nations, an annual international rugby tournament, teams who win all their matches achieve a “Grand Slam”. After victories over France, Italy and Wales, Ireland looked set to become the first team to do so twice in a row since the tournament expanded in 2000. But last weekend Ireland unexpectedly lost to an inspired England side. Victory or a draw against Scotland in Saturday’s final round of matches will still ensure they win the tournament. But failing to claim another Slam will be a disappointment—especially after the much fancied side crashed out in the quarter-finals of last year’s World Cup.

Elsewhere, the tournament has been encouraging for the Italians, who have beaten Scotland and drawn against France. Scotland humbled arch-rivals England but remained maddeningly inconsistent. France also struggled for steady form. This year’s Six Nations has been highly competitive, but that has prevented any team from imposing themselves.

Photo: Reuters

Weekend profile: Jimmy Chérizier, Haiti's top gang leader

In the days after Haiti's gangs took advantage of a trip abroad by Ariel Henry, the prime minister, to seize control of prisons and police stations, one man seemed to have authority. Jimmy "Barbecue" Chérizier, the country's most prominent warlord, was as present and vocal as Mr Henry was absent and silent. On Tuesday Mr Chérizier achieved his stated aim: Mr Henry said he would resign as soon as a transitional government was in place.

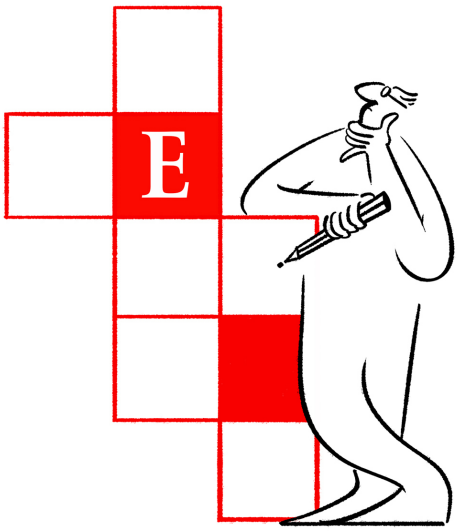
Mr Chérizier appears to have political ambitions. As foreign leaders discussed the contours of a transitional government, he warned that international decisions would plunge Haiti into "further chaos"; he then promised he would "figure out how to get Haiti out of the misery it's in now". But Mr Chérizier himself is responsible for much of that misery. He leads the G-9, a group that began with nine gangs and has since expanded. They are among the 300 gangs that control 80% of the capital.

Mr Chérizier portrays himself as the champion of the people in the Caribbean nation of 11.6m. The youngest of eight children, he grew

up in a slum in Port-au-Prince. He says his father died when he was a child and that his mother sold fried chicken on the street. (That, he claims, is the origin of his nickname, “Barbecue”, rather than any reference to setting his enemies on fire.) Mr Chérizier went on to join the Haitian police, one of the few decent jobs in the desperately poor country.

But the police sacked him in 2018 for alleged abuses, including taking part in a massacre at La Saline, a slum, in which at least 71 people died and 400 homes burned. Soon after, he was taking part in gang-led massacres in Port-au-Prince; he has subsequently been involved in many more. In 2020 he founded the G-9. Both the United States and the UN have imposed sanctions on Mr Chérizier. He has said that fighting with guns is necessary and that he is inspired by François Duvalier, also known as “Papa Doc”, a brutal dictator who ruled Haiti from 1957 to 1971.

Mr Chérizier may disrupt plans both for a transitional government and for the deployment of a security force authorised by the UN and led by Kenya. It cannot begin its mission while there is no government in Haiti. It is hard to imagine that Mr Chérizier, having come so far, will retreat into the background.



Weekly crossword

Our crossword is designed for experienced cruciverbalists and newcomers alike. Both sets of clues give the same answers, all of which feature in articles in this week's edition of *The Economist*:

Cryptic clues

1 down Confused TV diva looks for far eastern city (11)

1 across Ruined troves for those who mark the spot with an X (6)

2 across Planet is part of heaven, usually (5)

3 across Firstly keep up, then wait in state (6)

Factual clues

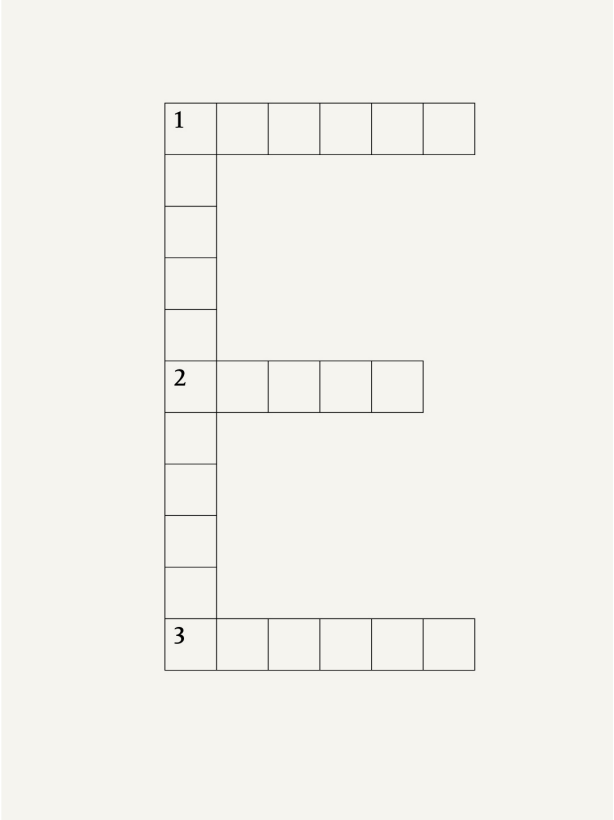
1 down The city where the Russian day begins (11)

1 across Who India's government is trying to mobilise with a controversial citizenship law (6)

2 across Subject of a famous painting by Sandro Botticelli (5)

3 across Home to one of the world's largest sovereign wealth funds (6)

Email all four answers by 9am GMT on Monday to , along with your home city and country. We will pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners in next week's edition.



The winners of this week’s quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week’s quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Pär Arumskog, Uppsala, Sweden

Stephen O’Brien, London, Britain

Colin Eyssen, Vancouver, Canada

They all gave the correct answers of *Mexico*, *Jersey*, *the house of Orleans*, *York* and *Hampshire*. The theme is *places in America that start with New*: *New Mexico*, *New Jersey*, *New Orleans*, *New York* and *New Hampshire*.

The questions were:

Monday: The Institutional Revolutionary Party ruled which country continuously from 1929 to 2000?

Tuesday: Which is the largest of the Channel Islands, which sit between England and France?

Wednesday: Louis Philippe, King of France from 1830 to 1848, stemmed from which cadet branch of the Bourbon family?

Thursday: The white rose was the symbol of which English royal house?

Friday: Which English county contains the cities of Portsmouth and Southampton?

> *Scratch a pessimist and you will often find a defender of privilege.*
>
> *William Beveridge*